Philosophy Lectures · outside the curriculum; it falls within History of Philosophy (2nd year) and Philosophy (1st year) · If God is dead, what is left? · Class 1 of 8 · With Javier

The madman with the lantern

Class video: https://youtu.be/RBvZ4jDxVIs
This sheet online: https://gincollab.github.io/aula/en/conf-filosofia/t01-c1/
The code leads to the video.

In a nutshell

It is a **lecture, not a class**: about seventeen minutes for listening and thinking, with no exercises, no countdowns and no questions to take home. Javier speaks from the school assembly hall. It is the first in a series of eight, "If God is dead, what is left?", and it stands on its own.

It is Javier's reading, and he says so. At the start he warns: "What I'm going to tell you is my way of seeing it. It isn't a dogma: listen to it, and then argue with it." He speaks in the first person, with few quotations, and with familiar images. The answer of those who believe is announced with all its weight, and it has its own lecture, number 7.

The question: where does the feeling that nothing holds firm come from? The lecture starts in the present: we have never had so much freedom to choose how to live and, at the same time, everything seems to be worth the same. Javier's thesis is that this emptiness has a history centuries long, and he tells it along a single line:

- **The chair.** For about a thousand years, in Europe, God sat in the chair at the centre: he answered what is true, what is right and what we live for.
- **The centre moves.** From Ptolemy, with the Earth motionless at the centre and his epicycles, to Copernicus (1543), with the loop of Mars explained by an Earth that overtakes it. Thomas Kuhn gave it as an example of a paradigm change. Descartes puts the starting point in the self ("I think, therefore I am"), even though he went on believing; Kant gives the Enlightenment its motto: "Dare to know!".
- **The madman with the lantern.** Nietzsche, a philologist before he was a philosopher, shouts it out in 1882 (*The Gay Science*, § 125). The madman lights a lantern in the broad light of morning, like Diogenes, and those who laugh at him are "many of those who did not believe in God". "We have killed him, you and I", and "God is dead!". And a question: is there still an up and a down, a north?

- **The news arrives in the 20th century**, with the existentialists. Heidegger: we are thrown into a world we did not choose, and our way of being is being-in-the-world; and Leibniz's question, "why is there something rather than nothing?". Sartre: man is condemned to be free. Simone de Beauvoir: being a woman is not written in advance, it is built. Camus: life does not come with a given meaning and, even so, it is worth it.
- **What died.** Nietzsche made it clear in 1887 (§ 343): not a being, but a faith, "faith in the Christian God has become unworthy of belief", and with it, what was built on it must collapse, "for example, our whole European morality". We go on living in the building: the 1948 Universal Declaration says that all human beings are born free and equal in dignity. But what does that rest on?
- **Freedom and vertigo.** A liberation that brings vertigo, like your first weekend home alone. What comes after it, nihilism: "the answer to the 'why?' is lacking". And, in Javier's words, a lot of quick pleasure is a way of not hearing that question.

The ending. The series' question, on its own: if God is dead, what is left? Javier does not give his answer. He leaves an idea: the chair will not stay empty, and if you don't decide what is worthwhile, someone else will decide for you: fashion, the algorithm or the strongest, "like some of today's political leaders, who want to go back to a world of force, not of reason".

Objective. By the end, students will know where the feeling that nothing holds firm comes from, according to a reading that presents itself as such: the line that runs from a world with God at the centre, through Copernicus and Descartes, to Nietzsche's sentence and the existentialism of the 20th century. And they will know why the lecture leaves the series' question open.

What it doesn't do. It gives no verdict on God. Nietzsche was an atheist and the lecture says so, but the madman is a character, and those who believe have their reasons. The final criticism is not aimed at a belief or at a party: it is aimed at force placed above reason, as the channel always does. There is no homework: the full texts are on the student worksheet, for anyone who wants to read them.

For readers outside Spain: the Bachillerato is the last two years of secondary school (ages 16–18); Philosophy is compulsory in the first year for every track, and History of Philosophy in the second. On this sheet, "1st year" and "2nd year" (1.º and 2.º in Spanish) are those two years. Royal Decree 243/2022 sets the minimum curriculum of the Bachillerato for the whole of Spain; the Philosophy Lectures are one of the channel's series and sit outside it. The video is in Spanish, with English subtitles. On this sheet the quotations are our own English translations from their originals (German, French, Latin and Greek), and the words of the Universal Declaration are the UN's official English ones. A *comentario de texto*, or text commentary, is the classic Spanish classroom exercise of explaining a philosophical passage in writing.

Where it falls in the curriculum

The Lectures sit outside the curriculum: they neither follow the syllabus nor replace it. But this one falls squarely within it (Spain's Royal Decree 243/2022, annex II; the decree's wording, in our translation of the official Spanish text):

Subject and block	What the decree says	What the lecture adds
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block C	"The deconstruction of the Western tradition in Friedrich Nietzsche and the postmodern legacy."	The death of God, read in its two main texts, § 125 and § 343, and nihilism
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block C	"Existentialism: Martin Heidegger and Jean Paul Sartre" and "The contemporary development of feminism: Simone de Beauvoir".	A first look at all three, and at Camus, as the arrival of the news: each of them later has a lecture of their own
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, blocks B and C	"The scientific revolution", "Rationalism and empiricism: René Descartes and David Hume" and "The Enlightenment project: the power and the limits of reason".	From Ptolemy to Copernicus, the *cogito* and Kant's motto, as steps of a centre that moves
History of Philosophy, 2nd year, block B	"The problem of the relationship between faith and reason."	Faith as the foundation of morality, and the question of what dignity rests on today
Philosophy, 1st year, block B.2	"The philosophical problem of the existence of God. Theism, atheism and agnosticism."	It tells the existence of God apart from belief in him: § 343 speaks of faith, not of a proof
Philosophy, 1st year, block C.1	"Nietzsche's amoral morality" and "The debate around moral relativism".	"When everything is worth the same, nothing is worth much", and the match without a referee: who decides what is a foul?

How the lecture is built

Video chapters

Minute	Chapter
0:00	What happens to us

Minute	Chapter
1:57	The chair
5:25	The madman with the lantern
8:46	I come too early
12:28	What died
14:11	Freedom and vertigo
15:47	What is left?

- **Seven chapters**, each with something that moves, so that seventeen minutes don't weigh heavy: the phone and its cards, the village and its bells, Ptolemy's universe turning into Copernicus's, the madman's market, the match without a referee, the newborn who falls into a world already made, the real page from 1887, the building that cracks, the empty house and the chair with its shadows.
- **Eight pauses**, of 3 to 4 seconds. Javier asks a question and falls silent, without warning and without a countdown. Four of them go straight to the listener, about their own life:
- Out of everything you can choose, what is truly worthwhile?
- After Kant's motto, "Dare to know!": "Of everything you believe, how much have you thought out for yourself?"
- In a match without a referee, who decides what is a foul?
- Sartre's student, torn between fighting the Nazis and looking after his mother: "And you, in his place, what would you do?" Sartre's answer comes afterwards.
- If the foundation cracks, what happens to the building?
- After quick pleasure, which keeps the question from being heard: "Why do you do what you do every day?"
- The series' question, on its own, large and in silence: if God is dead, what is left?
- With the chair still empty: "And you, what are you going to do?"
- **The astronomy, told properly.** The loop of Mars is calculated with its real orbit (1.52 times the Earth's, 1.88 years). Ptolemy's epicycle and, in Copernicus, the Earth overtaking Mars are the same motion seen from two places: that is why Copernicus explained it "naturally". He went on using a few small epicycles to make the numbers come out, but no longer for the backward motion.
- **Each quotation, with its work** on screen. Javier reads them; the authors are given no voice (article 15 of the channel's Constitution). The translations into Spanish are our own and literal, checked against the original; the Universal Declaration is quoted in the UN's official Spanish text.

Using it in class, if you wish

The lecture sets no task. If teachers want to use it, here are three ways of doing so, from least to most time:

- **Reading aloud.** § 125 takes about four minutes to read. Read before watching the lecture, it lets students reach the market scene with their own reading.
- **With 1st-year students, fifteen minutes of dialogue after watching it.** Three questions, with no single answer:
- Why do the unbelievers laugh at the madman? What is it that, according to him, they still haven't understood?
- In the match without a referee, who should decide what is a foul? Is any answer valid?
- The 1948 Declaration does not say what dignity rests on. What does it rest on, for you?
- **With 2nd-year students, a text commentary.** § 125 or § 343, in full on the student worksheet, in English and in German. The lecture serves as an introduction, and does not do the commentary for them: it deliberately leaves out a good part of the text ("the gravediggers", "the divine putrefaction", "a higher history", the churches as the tombs of God).

Misreadings the lecture takes apart

What is often said	What the text says
"God is dead" is an atheist's jibe at believers	In § 125 it is the unbelievers who mock, and they mock the madman. It weighs on the madman: "How do we console ourselves?" Nietzsche was indeed an atheist, but the madman is a character, and in the scene nobody celebrates
Nietzsche says that there was a God and that he died	§ 343: "faith in the Christian God has become unworthy of belief". What dies is a belief
With Copernicus, the epicycles were over	Copernicus went on using small epicycles to make the numbers come out (*De revolutionibus*, V 4). What he explained without them was the backward motion
Diogenes was looking for "an honest man"	Diogenes Laertius (VI 41) says ἄνθρωπον ζητῶ, "I am looking for a human being". The "honest" is a later addition

What is often said	What the text says
Almost every country signed the Universal Declaration	It was not signed: it was voted on by the UN General Assembly, which had 58 members. There were 48 votes in favour, none against and 8 abstentions

Going further: what the lecture doesn't say aloud

- **«Dios ha muerto» or «Dios está muerto».** «Gott ist todt» is, literally, "God is dead" («Dios está muerto»), which is also the usual wording in English; the usual Spanish formula is «Dios ha muerto» ("God has died").
- **Nietzsche in Basel.** He was elected extraordinary professor of classical philology in February 1869, aged 24, and full professor in April 1870 (his letters, in the eKGWB).
- **Heidegger and Leibniz's question.** He closes *What Is Metaphysics?* (1929) with it, and opens *Introduction to Metaphysics* (lecture course of 1935) with it. Leibniz had asked it in 1714, and had answered it: the ultimate reason of things is called God (*Principles of Nature and Grace*, §§ 7–8).
- **Camus denied being an existentialist** (Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Albert Camus"). That is why the lecture does not count him among them: it says he thought «en la misma época» ("in the same period"). His lecture, number 6, goes into it.
- **Heidegger and Nazism.** His membership of the Nazi party is told in his lecture, number 4. In this one, only his idea of being thrown into the world appears.
- **Nihilism** is defined in a notebook (posthumous fragment from autumn 1887, 9[35]), not in a published work, and the lecture words it that way: «cuadernos de 1887» ("notebooks of 1887").

Open resources

- *The Gay Science*, in German, in the digital critical edition (eKGWB): http://www.nietzschesource.org/#eKGWB/FW-125 and http://www.nietzschesource.org/#eKGWB/FW-343
- The 1887 edition, scanned (archive.org, public domain): https://archive.org/details/bub_gb_LNEuAAAAYAAJ
- The Universal Declaration of Human Rights, on the UN website: https://www.un.org/en/about-us/universal-declaration-of-human-rights
- Kant, "What Is Enlightenment?", in German, on Wikisource: https://de.wikisource.org/wiki/Beantwortung_der_Frage:_Was_ist_Aufkl%C3%A4rung%3F
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy: "Friedrich Nietzsche", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/nietzsche/, and "Existentialism", https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/existentialism/

Sources

- Nietzsche, *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*, Chemnitz: Schmeitzner, 1882 (e-rara, doi:10.3931/e-rara-72849), and Leipzig: Fritzsch, 1887 (archive.org); eKGWB FW-125 and FW-343. Posthumous fragment from autumn 1887, 9[35]; *Der Wanderer und sein Schatten*, § 18 (1880); letters BVN-1869,608, BVN-1869,614 and BVN-1870,71.
- Ptolemy, *Almagest*, books IX–XIII; MacTutor, "Ptolemy". Copernicus, *De revolutionibus orbium coelestium*, Nuremberg, 1543, I 9–10 and V 3–4.
- Kuhn, *The Copernican Revolution* (1957), ch. 1, p. 1; *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962; 2nd ed., 1970), pp. 68 and 117.
- Descartes, *Discours de la méthode*, 1637, part 4 (AT VI 32 and 38). Kant, "Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?", *Berlinische Monatsschrift*, 1784, p. 481 (AA VIII 35).
- Heidegger, *Sein und Zeit*, 1927, § 12 and § 29, pp. 53–54, 135, 240, 253 and 266; *Was ist Metaphysik?*, 1929. Leibniz, *Principes de la nature et de la grâce*, 1714, §§ 7–8 (Gerhardt VI 602).
- Sartre, *L'existentialisme est un humanisme*, Paris: Nagel, 1946 (lecture of 29/10/1945). Beauvoir, *Le Deuxième Sexe*, 1949, II, part 1, ch. I. Camus, *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, 1942.
- UN, Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Resolution 217 A (III), 10/12/1948, article 1; the vote, in the Dag Hammarskjöld Library, record 670964.
- Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers*, VI 23 and VI 41 (Hicks's edition, Perseus). Le Goff, "Au Moyen Âge : temps de l'Église et temps du marchand", *Annales ESC*, 1960 (the bells).
- The checks, quotation by quotation, with the original and the translation (in Spanish): `clases/conf-filosofia-t01-c1/verificacion-citas.md` and `verificacion-citas-2.md`.

Reading them: editions and free copies

Each work, with an English translation of reference (checked in two sources on 05/11/2026) and, where there is one, a free and legal copy.

- **Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*** (1882; 2nd ed., 1887): tr. Walter Kaufmann, Vintage, 1974. Free: the 1910 translation by Thomas Common, at Project Gutenberg; in German, at Nietzsche Source.
- **Nietzsche, notebook of autumn 1887, 9[35]**: in *Writings from the Late Notebooks*, ed. Rüdiger Bittner, tr. Kate Sturge, Cambridge University Press, 2003. Free, in German: Nietzsche Source.
- **Nietzsche, *The Wanderer and His Shadow*** (1880), § 18: in *Human, All Too Human*, tr. R. J. Hollingdale, Cambridge University Press, 2nd ed., 1996. Free: the 1913 translation, at Project Gutenberg; in German, at Nietzsche Source.
- **Ptolemy, *Almagest*** (2nd c.): tr. G. J. Toomer, Princeton University Press, 1998. Free, in Greek and French: Halma's edition, 1816, scanned.
- **Copernicus, *On the Revolutions*** (1543): tr. Edward Rosen, Johns Hopkins University Press. Free, in Latin: the first edition, scanned.

- **Kuhn, *The Copernican Revolution*** (1957): Harvard University Press.
- **Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*** (1962): University of Chicago Press, 50th anniversary ed., 2012.
- **Descartes, *Discourse on Method*** (1637): tr. Donald A. Cress, Hackett, 3rd ed., 1998. Free, in French: Wikisource.
- **Kant, "What Is Enlightenment?"** (1784): in *Political Writings*, ed. H. S. Reiss, tr. H. B. Nisbet, Cambridge University Press, 2nd ed., 1991. Free, in German: Wikisource.
- **Leibniz, *Principles of Nature and Grace*** (1714): in *Philosophical Essays*, ed. and tr. Roger Ariew and Daniel Garber, Hackett, 1989.
- **Heidegger, *Being and Time*** (1927): tr. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson, Harper.
- **Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*** (1946): tr. Carol Macomber, Yale University Press, 2007.
- **Beauvoir, *The Second Sex*** (1949): tr. Constance Borde and Sheila Malovany-Chevallier, Vintage, 2011.
- **Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*** (1942): tr. Justin O'Brien, Penguin Modern Classics.
- **UN, *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*** (1948): the official text, at un.org.
- **Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers***, book VI: tr. R. D. Hicks, Loeb Classical Library 185, 1925. Free, at Wikisource.
- **Le Goff, "Merchant's Time and Church's Time in the Middle Ages"** (1960): in *Time, Work, and Culture in the Middle Ages*, tr. Arthur Goldhammer, University of Chicago Press, 1980. Free, in French: Persée.

About this lecture

Javier is an illustrated character and his voice is synthetic. The script is written by an AI (Claude, by Anthropic) and reviewed by a person. Every fact and every quotation has been checked in the original source or in two sources. This English version was translated by the same AI. This sheet is licensed under CC BY 4.0.

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